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Fedric Kujur & Rajib Roy

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Enhancing institutional reputation through personal branding: a study of employee advocacy in Indian academia

Fedric Kujur[a] and Rajib Roy[b]

[a]Marketing Management, Xavier Institute of Social Service (XISS), Ranchi, India; [b]Strategy & General Management, Jaipuria Institute of Management, Noida, India

ABSTRACT

This paper examines how such personal branding influences Indian academicians university professors to perform as organizational evangelists. It investigates the processes of perceived value of personal branding as a mediator in this relationship and digital literacy as a potential moderator. A quantitative strategy was adopted and data were collected from 449 Indian professors belonging to different disciplines using a structured questionnaire. Along with confirmatory factor analysis and exploratory factor analysis, structural equation modeling was employed to analyze the data. The findings indicate that, even though perceived value plays a minor mediating role, employee advocacy behavior is strongly influenced by personal branding, the support of the organization and the identity of the occupation. Professional identity and advocacy are positively moderated by digital literacy and faculty members who are tech-savvy are more competent to be advocates. The research contributes to the necessity of resonating institutional strategies to faculty branding, and underlines how digital competencies can support raising institutional visibility and competitiveness.

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Personal branding; employee advocacy; academic institutions; digital literacy; professional identity

1. Introduction

Personal branding increasingly influences education, enabling professors to build professional identities beyond their institutional roles. According to Rangarajan et al. (2017), the 'personal branding' concept is a way an individual can differentiate himself/herself in a competitive market; it is about selling yourself (Kaputa, 2012), in which a person owns a brand warranty and get-up (Labrecque et al., 2011). Professors use digital platforms to strengthen personal brands through engagement, knowledge sharing, self-promotion, and increased academic and public visibility (Veletsianos, 2016). Professors use platforms like LinkedIn, ResearchGate, and Twitter to enhance personal branding, expanding institutional visibility, professional networking, research dissemination, and public engagement NapoleonCat (2023). Digital platforms such as Twitter enable professors to engage scholars and the public, expanding academic influence, collaboration, research dissemination, and personal branding beyond traditional academia. Personal branding, employee advocacy, institutionality and professional identity are co-related mechanisms

CONTACT Fedric Kujur fedrickujur@gmail.com
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that coalesce at the core of influencing an institution's reputation in higher education institutions. Institutional support facilitates branding processes and professional identity strengthens advocacy practices by stronger motto – congruence with the institution. Deep learning uses neural networks for predictive modeling, enabling accurate classification and prediction from large datasets.

Simultaneously, *employee advocacy* has emerged as a key behavior in which individuals voluntarily promote their organizations through personal networks and digital platforms, serving as unofficial ambassadors (Men, 2014a; Wright & Hinson, 2017). Although extensively studied in corporate environments – where it has been shown to significantly enhance organizational reputation, trust, and employee engagement (Men, 2014b) – employee advocacy's role in academia remains underexplored. Professors, as though leaders and influencers in their fields, often serve as institutional advocates, whether through public appearances, academic publications, or social media engagement (Dreher, 2014). This advocacy not only enhances the institution's reputation but also strengthens the personal brand of the professor.

Professors' personal branding advances academic careers while strengthening institutional reputation through research excellence, advocacy, and program promotion (Edwards, 2010). All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2020-2021 released by the Ministry of Education, Government of India (2021a) reported 1,113 universities and 43,796 colleges in India. Institutions such as IITs and IIMs promote faculty personal branding to enhance professors' visibility and strengthen institutional reputation. Universities encourage faculty public speaking and social media engagement to boost personal and institutional visibility, contributing to improved global recognition and GEURS 2025 rankings. IIT Delhi, IISc Bangalore, and IIT Bombay achieved high employability rankings through enhanced faculty visibility, media engagement, and personal branding initiatives.

Personal branding among Indian academicians is hindered by limited digital literacy, inadequate internet access, and insufficient institutional support. According to IAMAI (Internet and Mobile Association of India) [IAMAI], 2020), nearly 50% of India's population lacks internet access, while many universities provide limited media training, digital tools, and professional development opportunities. Limited institutional support creates unequal personal branding opportunities across Indian academia (Rangarajan et al., 2017). Media quality modeling evaluates visual, textual, and engagement features to predict advertising effectiveness.

Government initiatives such as Digital India and NEP 2020 aim to reduce the digital divide by improving internet access and digital skills, enabling professors to strengthen personal branding and global academic engagement. This study examines how personal branding, institutional support, and professional identity influence employee advocacy, while analyzing the mediating role of perceived branding value and the moderating effect of digital literacy in Indian academia.

2. Literature review

2.1. Comprehensive literature review on personal branding

Personal branding, introduced by Tom Peters (1997), helps individuals strategically manage professional identity, reputation, and market perception across academic careers

(Peters, 1997). The digital era has increased personal branding's importance, encouraging academics to enhance visibility, networking, influence, career growth, and public credibility (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Harris & Rae, 2011; Labrecque et al., 2011). Labrecque et al. (2011) and Khedher (2014) found in their studies that authenticity-led personal branding on social media boosts audience trust, engagement, and advocacy actions. Digital platforms enhance personal brand value and stakeholder perceptions, extending personal branding from public figures to professionals in business and education (Parmentier et al., 2013; Shepherd, 2005). Social media and digital platforms democratize personal branding by enabling individuals to build identities, influence, and professional networks (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Veletsianos, 2016).

Evolving careers require continuous personal branding to maintain professional relevance, visibility, and opportunities across changing jobs and sectors (Khedher, 2014; Montoya & Vandehey, 2002). University scholars must secure funding, publish extensively, and maintain strong public visibility to remain globally competitive in academia (Sugimoto et al., 2017; Veletsianos, 2016; Wright & Hinson, 2015). In the digital era, academics strengthen personal brands through online visibility, complementing traditional achievements such as teaching, publications, and institutional service to remain globally competitive (Labrecque et al., 2011; Sugimoto et al., 2017; Veletsianos, 2016).

2.2. Theoretical framework: social identity Theory and Self-Determination Theory

Understanding the relationship between personal branding and employee advocacy in academia can be enriched by examining two well-established theoretical frameworks: Social Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979) and Self-Determination Theory (Deci & Ryan, 1985). These theories provide complementary perspectives on how professors' personal and institutional roles intertwine, influencing their behavior as advocates for their academic institutions. Personal branding in educational institutions remains grounded in academic ethics, authenticity, transparency, and responsible professional conduct to preserve scholarly credibility and trust. At the same time, excessive emphasis on self-promotion may create tensions with traditional academic values centered on knowledge sharing and collective academic contribution.

Social identity theory explains professors' professional identity through strong institutional affiliation, enhancing commitment, belonging, and organizational engagement. Faculty members with strong organizational identification may perceive institutional achievements as an extension of their own professional success (Yang & Mostafa, 2024). From this identification emanate various forms of advocacy (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Edwards, 2010; Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004) such as advocacy behaviour towards improving the standing of the individual and the institution. Professors with strong personal brands promote institutional reputation through research, conferences, networking, and academic engagement (Edwards, 2010). Because they are represented by the institutional brand, educators turn their personal branding to serve as advocates for their institutions. Social Identity Theory explains how professors develop institutional attachment and advocacy behavior, whereas Self-Determination Theory explains the intrinsic motivational processes driving branding engagement. Together, these theories provide a complementary framework linking institutional identification with autonomous professional behavior in digital academic environments.

Conversely, Self-Determination Theory (SDT) (Deci & Ryan, 1985) provides an explanation of intrinsic motivation in the context of personal branding activities. Faculty use personal branding to fulfill autonomy, demonstrate competence, build professional relationships, and strengthen academic identity and engagement (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Professors with stronger personal branding actively promote their universities, supporting institutional reputation and advancing career growth and recognition (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Vansteenkiste et al., 2020). Based on Social Identity Theory (SIT) and Self-Determination Theory (SDT), the present framework explains how institutional attachment and intrinsic motivation simultaneously affect faculty branding and advocacy behavior. As one, these perspectives adequately describe employee advocacy in digital academic environments. Integrating these theories explains how institutional identification, competence, and autonomy motivate professors to strengthen institutional advocacy and personal branding, aligning individual and institutional achievements for mutual professional and organizational benefits.

2.3. Personal branding in academia

Personal branding has become essential for academics, expanding beyond publications, grants, and teaching evaluations through digital platforms that enhance professional visibility, influence, and academic impact within and beyond academia (Shepherd, 2005). In the Indian academic environment, faculty personal branding is strongly shaped by collectivist cultural values and a close association with institutional identity, where individual visibility often reinforces institutional reputation. As a result, professors typically adopt branding practices that balance professional self-promotion with responsible institutional representation.

Studies by Labrecque et al. (2011) and Gorbatov et al. (2018) stated that 'academics who self-promote actively secure more speaking engagements, research collaborations and career opportunities, highlighting the importance of personal branding in academic contexts'. Personal branding helps professors enhance visibility, credibility, and thought leadership despite concerns about self-promotion conflicting with academic values, ultimately supporting career growth and institutional reputation (Khedher, 2014).

2.4. Employee advocacy in educational institutions

Employee advocacy has been examined extensively in the corporate setting and found to enhance employee engagement, organizational trust, and brand reputation (Men, 2014a; Wright & Hinson, 2017; Harris & Rae, 2011). Within higher education, professors who participate in employee advocacy market their institutions by disseminating research results, engaging in public debates, and marketing curricular offerings (Edwards, 2010; Gorbatov et al., 2018). Men's (2014b) and Wright and Hinson (2017) research indicates that employees who view their organizational values as being in harmony with their own values will more likely perform advocacy behaviors. In higher education, this is often moderated by institutional support, professional identity, and digital literacy. Professors who believe their personal and institutional goals to be aligned are also more likely to serve as institutional advocates, and, conversely, those with a divide/separation between

their personal and professional identities may be less likely to serve as advocates (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004).

2.5. Institutional support

Institutional support through media training, digital tools, and professional development enables faculty to strengthen personal branding, enhance visibility, and effectively contribute to both individual career advancement and institutional reputation (Men, 2014a; Grigore et al., 2024; Vansteenkiste et al., 2020). Institutional support strengthens online visibility, aligns personal and institutional goals, and fosters belonging, enhancing mutual benefits for faculty and institutions (Men, 2014b; Edwards, 2010). Institutional investment in professors' development encourages advocacy behaviors, motivating faculty to promote institutional achievements through public speaking, media, and social media. Variations in digital literacy outcomes across Indian academic institutions can be attributed to differences in access to media support, digital infrastructure, and professional development opportunities. Such disparities in institutional resource accessibility influence faculty engagement in personal branding and limit participation in advocacy-oriented academic activities.

Further, Dreher (2014) institutional support motivates professors to engage in employee advocacy, encouraging public institutional endorsement as an extension of their personal professional success. A supportive institutional communication culture encourages faculty participation in advocacy activities by facilitating knowledge sharing, openness, and collaborative academic engagement. Transparent communication practices further strengthen faculty commitment to publicly representing institutional values and enhancing institutional reputation.

2.6. Professional identity

Professional identity shapes employee advocacy and personal branding by influencing academics' values, beliefs, goals, and commitment to their profession (Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004). Professors with strong professional identity engage in research, teaching and service, enhancing personal brand through unified scholarly consistent persona presentation (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Sugimoto et al., 2017).

In a similar vein, professional identity plays a large role in employee advocacy. Because they see the success of the institution as a reflection of their own, professors who are institutionally contoured are more likely to advocate for it (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Ashforth and Mael (1989) and Veletsianos (2016) also argued that alignment of personal and institutional narratives could motivate instructors to advocate for their institutions via their own public presence and on institutional web sites. In contrast to this, advocacy strategies may be attenuated when the personal identity and the institutional values are incompatible (Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004).

Professors use digital platforms strategically to align personal branding with institutional identity, enhancing both personal reputation and professional academic credibility (Priem et al., 2012; Veletsianos, 2016). Professional identity drives staff advocacy and personal branding, linking achievements to institutional success, enhancing reputation and demonstrating instructor competence.

2.7. The mediating role of perceived value of personal branding

Perceived job-market benefits of personal branding increase professors' engagement in personal and institutional promotion through value co-creation (Labrecque et al., 2011; Shepherd, 2005). Educators derive personal branding value from visibility and recognition gained through academic achievements, collaborations, and active public engagement (Vansteenkiste et al., 2020).

Labrecque et al. (2011) state professors using branding for career prospects align with institutions and increase employee advocacy. Khedher (2014) and Gorbatov et al., (2018) show perceived value of personal branding increases professors' advocacy, aligning personal and institutional goals. This creates a symbiotic relationship where branding supports career advancement and simultaneously enhances institutional reputation and academic engagement outcomes.

Khedher (2014) explains that when professors perceive personal branding supports institutional mission, they actively advocate for institutions, as perceived value mediates stronger engagement in promoting institutional achievements, success, and visibility.

2.8. The moderating role of digital literacy

Digital literacy moderates employee advocacy and personal branding; digitally skilled professors use online platforms to build academic profiles, collaborate, disseminate research globally, and more actively promote both personal and institutional achievements (Sugimoto et al., 2017; Veletsianos, 2016). Professors use platforms such as ResearchGate, LinkedIn, and blogs to showcase their research and build global professional networks; however, variations in digital literacy and access to digital resources in India may restrict opportunities for effective personal branding and employee advocacy (Veletsianos, 2016; Jordan, 2019). Rural professors lack digital tools and training compared to urban institutions, limiting personal branding opportunities and development. Digital literacy is conceived to be more than merely being able to use platforms which provide access to content management, networking, and professional communication across the academic disciplines. These factors increase faculty visibility, fortify the digital engagement process and yield better results from institutional advocacy.

In this way, digital literacy moderates the relationship between personal branding efforts and employee advocacy, influencing the extent to which professors can engage in these activities successfully (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Priem et al., 2012).

2.9. Hypotheses development

The strategic process of creating and developing a unique and recognizable personality to express knowledge and ideals is known as personal branding (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Labrecque et al., 2011). Employee work-based advocacy, or the promotion of an organization by its employees, has been proven to have a positive impact. It had a significant effect on them (Men, 2014a). Personal branding academics engage in research, events, and online presence, increasing visibility and institutional advocacy (Edwards, 2010). In academia, professors act as institutional ambassadors, improving reputation using

ResearchGate and managing personal branding through LinkedIn effectively (Veletsianos, 2016; Wright & Hinson, 2015). Professors' credibility is enhanced through personal branding, which makes them more effective in institutional promotion (Gorbatov et al., 2018).

H1: The relationship between personal branding activities and professors' employee advocacy is positive in academic institutions in India.

Facilitating professors to be involved in advocacy is a critical aspect of institutional support. behaviors. Support can be provided in the form of access to digital tools, professional development, program and resources for public engagement (Men, 2014b). When academic institutions Being well supported leads to higher levels of advocacy for the college or university (Edwards, 2010). Professor's perception of strong alignment between personal goals and the class' perception of their goals. Institutional objectives, with institutional support, are more likely to engage in. It can encourage an enhanced loyalty and attachment to the institution (Dreher, 2014; Gorbatov et al., 2018), and increase behaviours of advocacy (Gorbatov et al., 2018).

H2: The higher the level of institutional support, the more favorable the attitude of professor employees to promotion. Indian academic institutions.

Employee advocacy is greatly influenced by professional identity, which is defined as a person's internal image of his role in a profession (Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004). The teachers with a high sense of professional identity, according to Gorbatov et al. (2018), are those who have a strong sense of professional identity. Identity often think that success is tied to that of their institutions, and encourages them to do more advocacy. Those who are extremely close to their country. Those who are very attached to their country. The more an organization is involved in advocacy behaviors, the higher its organizational identification score is, in accordance with research by Ashforth and Mael (1989). As Veletsianos (2016) and Gorbatov et al. (2018) explain, professors build their professional reputation through their strong professional identity by encouraging research, teaching and institutional achievements.

H3: Professionality positively influences professors' advocacy if they are professors. Indian academic institutions.

Perceived value of personal branding refers to the extent to which individuals believe that personal branding can enhance their career prospects, recognition, and professional relationships (Labrecque et al., 2011). Professors who perceive personal branding as beneficial are more likely to engage in advocacy behaviors, seeing a direct connection between promoting their brand and their institution's success (Khedher, 2014). Research by Khedher (2014) highlights that professors who recognize the value of personal branding are more committed to aligning their branding efforts with institutional goals, enhancing the impact of personal branding on employee advocacy. Professional identity functions as an important

predictor of employee advocacy because stronger alignment between individual academic values and institutional objectives encourages greater institutional representation. Faculty members who identify closely with institutional goals demonstrate higher advocacy engagement.

H4: Perceived value of personal branding mediated the relationship between personal branding and employee advocacy for the professors in Indian academic institutions.

Personal branding and staff advocacy of professors are affected by institutional support, when it is deemed useful. Professors who build institutional and personal brands are more likely to derive value in doing so if they are supported with digital resources, professional development, or media training (Men, 2014a). Faculty development-supportive organizations promote more robust advocacy behaviors as instructors have the ability to 'advocate for themselves and their institutions' (Dreher, 2014).

H5: The perceived value of personal branding mediates the relationship between institutional support and employee advocacy amongst the professors embedded within Indian academic institutions.

Professional identity influences how professors value personal branding. Professors who identified strongly with their professions were more likely to view personal branding as a mechanism that improves their scholarly reputation and professional development (Kreiner & Ashforth, 2004). This correspondence between professional identity and the value of personal branding causes professors to identify with branding activities that feature both them and their institutions (Labrecque et al., 2011).

H6: The perceived value of personal branding mediates the relationship between professional identity and employee advocacy among professors in Indian academic institutions.

The association between employee advocacy and personal branding is somewhat moderated by digital literacy. Professors that possess a high level of digital literacy are better able to use digital platforms such as ResearchGate, LinkedIn, and Twitter to promote their institutions and develop their personal brands (Veletsianos, 2016). Professors who are more digitally literate can use online platforms for institutional and personal promotion, engaging in advocacy behaviors more successfully (Gorbatov et al., 2018).

H7: Digital literacy moderates the relationship between personal branding efforts and employee advocacy, such that the relationship is stronger for professors with higher digital literacy.

Additionally, the influence of institutional support on employee advocacy is moderated by digital literacy. Digitally literate professors are in a better position to leverage institutional resources to advance their institutional and personal brands. According to Rangarajan et al. (2017), digital literacy improves the efficiency of

institutional support by enabling instructors to make better use of the resources that their institutions offer.

H8: Digital literacy moderates the relationship between institutional support and employee advocacy, such that the relationship is stronger for professors with higher digital literacy.

Lastly, the association between employee advocacy and professional identity is moderated by digital literacy. Strong professional identities and digital literacy put professors in a better position to market their organizations and personal brands. Due to the growing use of online platforms for networking and research dissemination in academia, this moderating effect is particularly significant (Veletsianos, 2016). Higher digital literacy professors are better able to match their advocacy behaviors with their professional identities, making them more powerful representatives of their institutions (Gorbatov et al., 2018) (Refer Figure 1).

H9: Digital literacy moderates the relationship between professional identity and employee advocacy, such that the relationship is stronger for professors with higher digital literacy.

3. Research methodology

This quantitative study examines Indian professors, analyzing personal branding, institutional support, and professional identity on employee advocacy, with perceived value mediating and digital literacy moderating, using a structured questionnaire and convenience sampling. The participants were Indian professors, and the sample was drawn from different institutions of higher education in India to ensure geographical as well as

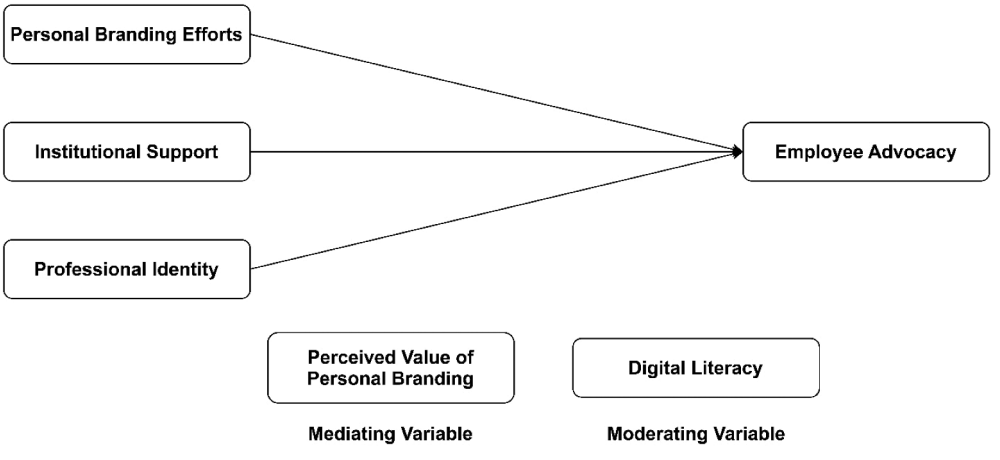


Figure 1. Conceptual framework of the study.

disciplinary diversity. Screening of responses was employed to reduce the impact of nonresponse and to enhance the external validity of results.

A self-administered questionnaire with two sections collected data: demographics and study constructs. It measured personal branding, institutional support, professional identity, perceived value, digital literacy, and employee advocacy using a 5-point Likert scale. The study included full-time professors and academic faculty members actively engaged in institutional teaching and professional activities during the survey period. Incomplete responses and participants not affiliated with higher education institutions were excluded from the final analysis.

The sample for this research consisted of 449 Indian professors from diverse academic institutions, a near equal gender split (58% male, 42% female), and varied age, rank, and disciplinary profiles. Most were working in private universities (65%), 40% had 6–10 years of experience, and the sample included disciplines such as Engineering, Business, Humanities, and Sciences. A snowball sampling technique was used to invite participants via institutional contacts and professional academic networks from several Indian higher education institutions. Participation was voluntary, anonymous and informed consent was obtained which ensures transparency and ethicality in the process of data collection.

The components of the questionnaire were adapted with the help of already validated scales from the literature relating to digital literacy, professional identity, institutional support, employee advocacy, personal branding, and perceived worth of personal branding. To ensure content validity and contextual relevance to the Indian higher education context the questionnaire was reviewed by university academics. Each construct was operationally defined and measured through a number of items based on well-established theoretical background that ranged anchored at two ends of a five-point Likert scale. Convenience sampling was used to select participants from higher education institutes across India. Full-time professors and academic staff (teaching and non-teaching) who are actively involved in research and institutional work were also eligible participant. This inclusion criterion ensured that participants had sufficient familiarity with and experience of employee advocacy and personal branding within academic settings.

3.1. Exploratory factor analysis (EFA)

EFA of this pool of items using PCA with Varimax rotation indicated a six-factor solution (eigenvalues > 1 for all factors) that accounted for 78.24% of the variance. These factors, which represent Institutional Support, Digital Literacy, Employee Advocacy, Personal Branding Activities, Professional Identity, and Perceived Value of Personal Branding, enable the measurement model to be considered appropriate for subsequent CFA and SEM analysis (see Table 1). The respondents belonged to higher education institutions from various Indian states/regions, which added to the geographical diversity and contextual coverage of academic faculty communities. This wider regional inclusion reinforced the generalization of the finding in the context of Indian higher education. The factor loading values show the magnitude of the association of each observed item with its latent construct. Loadings > 0.60 also indicate good item reliability and ensure that the indicators are adequate representatives of the latent constructs.

Table 1. List of items with their factor loadings.

Items	Codes	EFA Loadings	CFA Loadings
Personal Branding Efforts (PBE)			
I regularly manage my online presence to enhance my academic reputation.	PBE1	0.901	0.972
I engage in activities that showcase my research and expertise.	PBE2	0.881	0.952
I use social media platforms to build and promote my academic profile.	PBE3	0.781	0.626
My personal branding efforts contribute to achieving my career goals.	PBE4	0.761	0.651
Institutional Support (IS)			
My institution provides adequate encouragement for public and academic visibility.	IS1	0.964	0.97
I receive training and resources to effectively manage my professional identity.	IS2	0.962	0.988
Digital tools offered by my institution help facilitate my branding efforts.	IS3	0.953	0.975
Institutional support enhances my ability to engage in professional branding activities.	IS4	0.844	0.798
Professional Identity (PI)			
My academic contributions form an integral part of my professional identity.	PI1	0.864	0.824
I feel closely aligned with my institution's mission and goals.	PI2	0.843	0.816
My professional identity reflects my academic values and contributions.	PI3	0.817	0.779
I view my personal and institutional success as interconnected.	PI4	0.776	0.716
Perceived Value of Personal Branding (PVPB)			
Personal branding is a critical tool for advancing my academic career.	PVPB1	0.849	0.82
My branding efforts positively influence my professional relationships and collaborations.	PVPB2	0.84	0.828
Personal branding enhances my visibility and recognition in the academic community.	PVPB3	0.822	0.76
I believe personal branding benefits both my career and my institution.	PVPB4	0.772	0.705
Digital Literacy (DL)			
I am confident in using digital platforms to showcase my academic achievements.	DL1	0.944	0.977
My digital skills help me connect with a broader professional audience.	DL2	0.939	0.966
I frequently use online tools to enhance my academic and institutional visibility.	DL3	0.889	0.825
Digital literacy significantly impacts my professional success.	DL4	0.861	0.781
Employee Advocacy (EA)			
I actively promote my institution's achievements through social media or public forums.	EA1	0.844	0.806
I share my institution's successes with my professional network.	EA2	0.831	0.85
My personal success contributes to enhancing my institution's reputation.	EA3	0.829	0.82
I feel motivated to engage in activities that raise my institution's visibility.	EA4	0.828	0.804

3.2. Confirmatory aactor analysis (CFA)

With a CMIN/DF (Chi-square minimum divided by degrees of freedom) ratio of 1.861, CFI of 0.977, SRMR of 0.043 and RMSEA of 0.044, a CFA confirmed the good fit of the proposed model. The items of Institutional Support, Digital Literacy, Personal Branding Efforts, and the Perceived Value of Personal Branding are well associated with their factors, and the high factor loadings (0.626 to 0.988) indicate a good construct validity. Advertisement of products and services on the internet so that they can be purchased online by the customers is ecommerce advertising. Good advertisements increase sales conversion rate, consumer engagement and brand visibility. Although PBE3 and PBE4 showed relatively weaker factor loadings, both pila were above the cut-off values and conceptual relevance to personal branding behaviour. They kept the face validity of the construct and did not significantly affect convergent validity and composite reliability indices. Prior to factor extraction, exploratory factor analysis assumptions were evaluated through sample adequacy and inter-item correlation testing to confirm data suitability. The Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin measure and Bartlett's test of sphericity supported the appropriateness of latent factor extraction procedures.

3.3. Convergent and discriminant validity

Using CR, AVE, MSV, and HTMT to evaluate the convergent and discriminant validity, the study found that all constructs had adequate convergent validity and good internal consistency. Strong discriminant validity was validated by the HTMT analysis and the Fornell-Larcker criterion, indicating that the measurement model is valid and dependable for additional SEM investigation (see Tables 2 and 3). The degree of involvement and emotional bond that consumers form with a brand or commercial is referred to as consumer engagement. Increased loyalty and purchase intentions are frequently the results of higher involvement. Common method variance was assessed using Harman's single-factor test, where no single factor accounted for the majority of total variance, indicating limited method bias. Additionally, marker-variable assessment confirmed that common method effects did not substantially influence construct relationships. Discriminant validity was further supported through HTMT values remaining below recommended threshold levels and examination of cross-loading patterns showing stronger associations with intended constructs. These findings confirm conceptual distinctiveness among branding, identity, advocacy, and digital literacy variables. Common method bias was assessed to evaluate potential inflation of relationships arising from self-reported measures, and results indicated that method effects remained within acceptable limits. This assessment increased confidence in the observed associations among study constructs. Construct validity was assessed using Composite Reliability (CR), Average Variance Extracted (AVE), Maximum Shared Variance (MSV), and HTMT ratios. The reported values confirm acceptable reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity among the study constructs.

3.4. Structural equation modeling (SEM) results

The SEM analyses indicated an acceptable model fit: CMIN/DF = 2.313, CFI = 0.970, RMSEA = 0.054, although the SRMR = 0.105 implied that improvement would be necessary. The findings corroborated H1, H2, and H3, suggesting that personal

Table 2. Construct validity analysis.

	CR	AVE	MSV	IS	DL	EA	PBE	PI	PVPB
IS	0.966	0.876	0.076	**0.936**					
DL	0.939	0.795	0.058	0.115*	**0.892**				
EA	0.892	0.673	0.162	0.276***	0.234***	**0.820**			
PBE	0.885	0.667	0.162	0.204***	0.114*	0.403***	**0.816**		
PI	0.865	0.617	0.107	0.168**	0.116*	0.327***	0.232***	**0.785**	
PVPB	0.861	0.608	0.058	0.178***	0.241***	0.219***	0.224***	0.225***	**0.780**

Table 3. HTMT analysis.

	IS	DL	EA	PBE	PI	PVPB
IS						
DL	0.140					
EA	0.288	0.237				
PBE	0.256	0.123	0.408			
PI	0.200	0.138	0.328	0.258		
PVPB	0.208	0.235	0.234		0.236	

branding, institution support, and professional identity have a positive and significant impact on employee advocacy among professor (Refer Table 4). Although the SRMR value exceeded ideal thresholds, the overall structural model remained acceptable based on satisfactory CFI, RMSEA, and CMIN/DF indicators. Residual diagnostics suggested localized covariance inconsistencies rather than substantial structural misspecification. The structural model examined direct, mediating, and moderating relationships to explain how personal branding influences employee advocacy through perceived value and digital literacy mechanisms. The combined analytical approach enabled deeper understanding of faculty branding effectiveness across institutional contexts. The structural model fit was evaluated using multiple goodness-of-fit indices, including CMIN/DF, CFI, SRMR, and RMSEA. Values within recommended thresholds indicate that the proposed model adequately represents the observed data and supports hypothesis testing.

3.5. Mediation analysis

Positive, but nonsignificant, indirect effects of the perceived value of personal branding were observed in the association between personal branding efforts , institutional support , and professional identity , and employee advocacy . Although not a strong mediator, the perceived value of personal branding does have some effect on strengthening the relationships in support of partial H4, H5 and H6 (Refer Table 5). The partial mediation results indicate that the perceived value of personal branding contributes to employee advocacy but does not function as an independent explanatory mechanism. Faculty advocacy behavior emerges through the combined influence of institutional alignment, professional identity, and recognition of branding-related professional benefits. The insignificant mediation results indicate that perceived value alone does not fully explain faculty advocacy behavior and functions as a limited transmission mechanism. Employee advocacy appears to emerge through broader interactions among institutional support, professional identity, and digital engagement. Mediation effects were examined by estimating indirect

Table 4. SEM result.

Hypothesized Relationship			Estimate	Std. Estimate	S.E.	C.R.	P
PBE	—>	EA	0.290	0.318	0.044	6.523	***
IS	—>	EA	0.131	0.177	0.035	3.775	***
PI	—>	EA	0.226	0.220	0.052	4.303	***
PBE	—>	PVPB	0.141	0.166	0.043	3.297	***
IS	—>	PVPB	0.084	0.122	0.034	2.451	0.014
PI	—>	PVPB	0.163	0.170	0.051	3.187	0.001
PVPB	—>	EA	0.083	0.077	0.055	1.491	0.136

Table 5. Mediation analysis.

Indirect Path	Unstandardized Estimate	Lower	Upper	p-Value	Standardized Estimate
PBE –>PVPB –>EA	0.012	0	0.033	0.106	0.013
IS –>PVPB –>EA	0.007	0	0.021	0.104	0.009
PI –>PVPB –>EA	0.013	0	0.037	0.111	0.013

structural paths and evaluating their statistical significance using confidence intervals and standardized coefficients. This approach enabled interpretation of how perceived value influenced relationships between predictor variables and employee advocacy.

3.6. Moderation analysis

The results of the moderation analysis indicated that Digital Literacy positively moderated the association between Professional Identity and Employee Advocacy, and its positive influence on Personal Branding Efforts and Employee Advocacy approached significance. Yet, Digital Literacy failed to significantly alter the strength of the association between Institutional Support and Employee Advocacy, underscoring its pivotal function as a determinant in the promotion of personal and professional branding activities in higher education (Refer Table 6 and Figures 2, 3 & 4). Simple slopes analyses revealed that the positive association between professional identity and employee advocacy was stronger at higher levels of digital literacy. Comparisons of conditional effects also revealed greater advocacy outcomes for the faculty groups that were the most digitally literate.

4. Discussion

This research was conducted to investigate the importance of personal branding for employee advocacy among professors in Indian academic institutions with the inclusion of the effects of personal branding efforts, institutional support for personal branding, professional identity, digital literacy, and perceived value of personal branding towards

Table 6. Moderation analysis.

Hypothesized Relationship			Estimate	Std. Estimate	S.E.	C.R.	P
ZPBE	—>	ZEA	0.264	0.264	0.043	6.088	***
ZIS	—>	ZEA	0.152	0.152	0.043	3.522	***
ZPI	—>	ZEA	0.189	0.189	0.043	4.384	***
ZPBE_ZDL	—>	ZEA	0.074	0.076	0.042	1.759	0.079
ZIS_ZDL	—>	ZEA	0.021	0.021	0.045	0.463	0.643
ZPI_ZDL	—>	ZEA	0.101	0.107	0.041	−2.436	0.015
ZDL	—>	ZEA	0.132	0.132	0.042	3.124	0.002

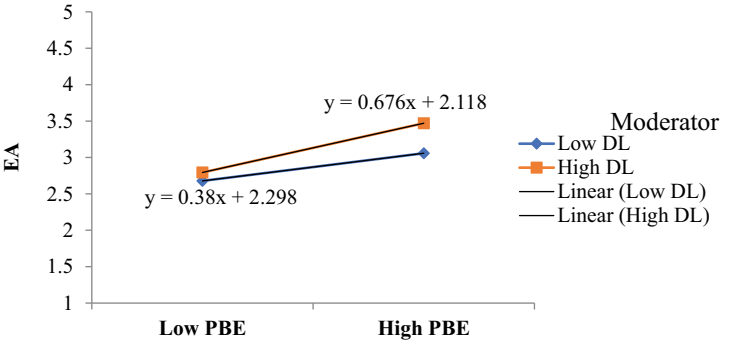


Figure 2. Moderating effect of DL between PBE and EA.

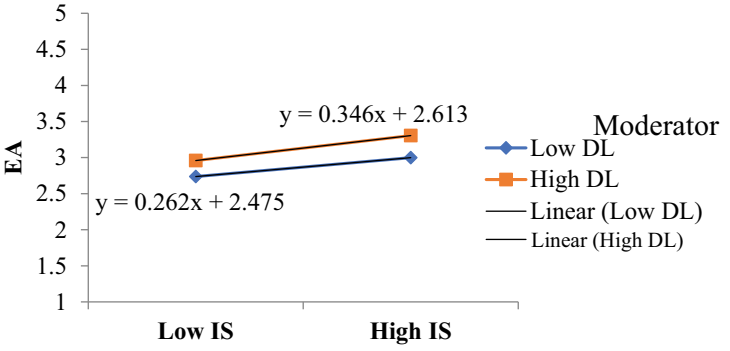


Figure 3. The moderating effect of DL between IS and EA.

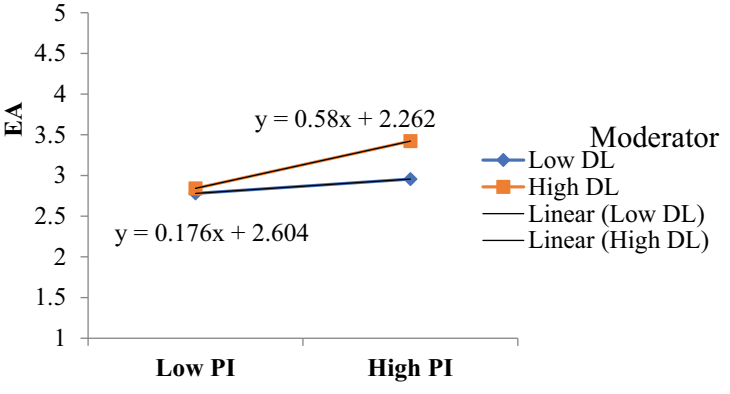


Figure 4. The moderating effect of DL between PI and EA.

advocacy behavior. This study adds to the emerging research on personal branding in academia by providing fresh insight on how academic staff leverage digital platforms not only to develop their career pathways, but also those of their organisations. The moderation analysis demonstrates that digital literacy strengthens the translation of professional identity into observable employee advocacy behaviors, particularly among faculty with greater capability to engage through digital platforms. This finding highlights the role of digital competence in amplifying institutional representation and enhancing the effectiveness of faculty branding activities.

Among Indian academics, personal branding positively influences employee advocacy, enhancing visibility and career opportunities, consistent with previous research findings (Gorbatov et al., 2018; Veletsianos, 2016). With personal branding, professors have a tool with which to promote themselves on an individual level and, in so doing, bring glory to their discipline and their institutional home (Dreher, 2014; Sugimoto et al., 2017). Along with parallel studies, this study highlights that scholars are representatives of their universities serving institutional (university) branding as well as personal ones (Labrecque et al., 2011). Sustainable marketing considers social, environmental, and economic impacts, promoting long-term value and responsible business practices.

Partially supported and non-significant relationships indicate that faculty advocacy behavior emerges through multiple interacting institutional and individual mechanisms rather than isolated effects. These findings reveal the complexity of academic branding processes within digital higher education environments.

Institutional support positively influences employee advocacy, as professors engage more when universities provide resources, training, and engagement opportunities. This is aligned with Edwards (2010) and Men (2014b) who highlight the role of institutional support in facilitating faculty involvement in efforts that promote the goals of the institution. In addition, the findings reported herein indicate that institutional support not only enhances personal branding efforts (Wright & Hinson, 2015; Gorbatov et al., 2018), but also plays a pivotal role in linking individual academic goals to institutional goals, a link that is essential for advocacy. These empirical findings reinforce the assumptions of Social Identity Theory and Self-Determination Theory by demonstrating that faculty advocacy emerges through both institutional identification and internally motivated branding behaviors. The statistical relationships therefore provide theoretical support for understanding academic branding processes.

Strong professional identity increases employee advocacy, as professors align personal academic values with institutional goals and actively promote their universities. This is consistent with Social Identity Theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1979), which postulates that people who have a strong sense of identity with an organization – in this case, an academic institution – are more inclined to act in ways that are consistent with that identity (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). Findings align with Veletsianos (2016) and Gorbatov et al. (2018), showing strong professional identity enhances institutional and personal reputation.

Institutional support, professional identity, and personal branding strongly influence employee advocacy directly, but perceived value of personal branding shows weak mediation, despite encouraging professors' advocacy engagement. Contrary to Khedher (2014) and Shepherd (2005) perceived value of personal branding weakly influences outcomes, suggesting intrinsic motivations matter more than perceived material benefits in shaping advocacy and institutional alignment (Labrecque et al., 2011; Sugimoto et al., 2017).

The study identifies employee advocacy and the digital literacy as critical factors, with digital literacy significantly moderating their relationships. Professional identity, institutional support, and personal branding are key influences. Results show strong moderation effects, especially between employee advocacy and professional identity, indicating that higher digital literacy enhances advocacy outcomes and strengthens institutional and individual engagement behaviors within higher education contexts. According to Veletsianos (2016), this implies that instructors who possess greater levels of digital literacy have an improved ability to leverage digital platforms to market their institutions and their advocacy behaviors are increased through professional identities, which in turn increase advocacy behaviors. The result is consistent with the findings of other studies. According to the research of Gorbatov et al. (2018) and Labrecque et al. (2011), digital technology is becoming increasingly important and is expected to be a significant factor in the future growth of the sector. In the digital age, literacy is a necessary enabler for the academic professionals to be able to do their jobs effectively. Network, advocate and disseminate research using digital resources. However, there was an important

moderation of the relationship between digital literacy and the other variables: (1) digital literacy and the perceived motor skills (2) digital literacy and the perceived attitudes towards the future, (3) professional identity and employee advocacy, its impact on the personal to professional relationship, and its influence on the workplace. Its impact on the personal to professional relationship, how it affects professional identity and how it affects the workplace. The other two factors – branding efforts and employee advocacy (H7) – were only slightly significant. This indicates that digital literacy helps to improve personal branding strategies but it is not the most while it is important for enhancing personal branding efforts, it may not be the most important one. Identity is a decisive in the advocacy process. This is in contrast to Veletsianos (2016), who suggested that digital skills are the primary driver of successful This book is designed for academic self-promotion, and offers a more sophisticated understanding of the function of digital. The book is intended for academic self-promotion and offers a more sophisticated understanding of the function of digital academic advocacy tools. The results of this study are in line with a number of other recent studies on academic personal branding. Veletsianos (2016) and Gorbatov et al. (2018) found that it is significant of personal branding in academic career development, particularly in digital branding platforms. According to Labrecque et al. (2011) and Sugimoto et al. (2017), these platforms provide academics an opportunity to reach broader audiences, share their research and findings, demonstrate their competence. By demonstrating how personal branding supports both individual career development and institutional advocacy, this study expands on existing knowledge and proposes that faculty members' personal brands have a reciprocal relationship with students' learning experiences and institutional reputation (Ashforth & Mael, 1989).

This study echoes the research of Edwards, (2010), Wright & Hinson (2015), and Men (2014a), all have claimed that institutional resources like training, digital tools and public engagement are key to allowing for faculty to become advocates for those behaviors. Institutional support has been provided to help the program succeed. It is demonstrated to have been effective in promoting a sense of belonging and personal institution in line with the institution. Professors are encouraged to promote their institutions, which is the reason for the call for their motivation (Dreher, 2014; Rangarajan et al., 2017). In addition, Dreher (2014) also discovered that institutional boosts their job satisfaction, thereby helping them deliver better teaching. In turn, it aids faculty members' professional growth, leading to higher job satisfaction and better teaching improves their capacity to support their own successes as well as the success of the institution success. Artificial Intelligence (AI) helps machines carry out tasks that would otherwise be done by humans. Intelligence – learning, reasoning and decision making. In marketing, AI contributes to enhancing. Use of personalization and campaign optimization. Unlike Khedher (2014), our results show that there are other factors including intrinsic are more important in motivating, aligning and shaping professional priorities and institutional cultures. While professors who know the practical advantages of personal advocacy have noted positive results, advocacy behaviors have not been the norm in higher education. Cultivating branding – including career progression and visibility – is more likely to engage in. Involving in branding activities (Ryan & Deci, 2000), the findings offer new insights in the intricacy of these interactions in the academic context, contradicting previous assertions that, 'The classroom was a place of harmony and order' (p. 70). The perceived worth of personal branding alone is

a potent enough mediator in the advocacy process (Labrecque et al., 2011; Shepherd, 2005). It has been acknowledged that digital literacy plays an important part in the moderation of advocacy activities in recent studies (Veletsianos, 2016). These correspond to our study in which we found that: proposing the concept of a continuum of digital literacy's influence, where, in some cases, digital literacy is only mildly impacting and in others it is having a strong impact, and more of an impact on the relationship between professional identity and employee advocacy than on personal branding activities. Professors with a higher digital literacy are better able to use online platforms to impact on institutional objectives, improving the attitudes towards advocacy behaviors (Sugimoto et al., 2017). This is indicative that there is a need for greater exploration. In the interaction between digital skills, professional identity and institutional support in academic settings (Gorbatov et al., 2018). The significant effect of professional identity demonstrates that identity-based commitment encourages professors to promote institutional accomplishments through academic interactions and professional networks. Such engagement enhances both institutional reputation and faculty influence within broader scholarly communities.

4.1. Practical implications

This study highlights the role of digital literacy and institutional support in the faculty advocacy process. Professors also ought to do some personal branding on sites like LinkedIn and Twitter and use institutional resources to assist them in that in doing so they can bring glory to the alma mater as well as themselves. Digital literacy results in Indian higher education demonstrate how access to technological infrastructure, institutional funding and digital capacity-building is stratified along rural-urban institutional lines. With more substantial digital ecosystems and support from the institution, community college faculty members in urban and resource-rich campuses are more able to apply their digital know-how to personal branding and advocacy as employees. Professors extend personal branding into institutional advocacy as they utilize professional visibility and academic clout to signal institutional excellence and accomplishments. This process establishes a strategic relationship between the individual process of reputation building and the collective process of how an institution's brand is built.

4.2. Limitations and future research directions

The limitations of this study involve the study population, which included only Indian professors and the potential data bias due to self-reporting. Future studies may take a cross-cultural perspective, incorporate longitudinal or behavioral data, and consider investigating other factors including satisfaction of work, cognitive institutional prestige, and moderating effects of digital literacy in different disciplines. Minimal mediation effects also indicate that employee advocacy behavior may be facilitated by other psychological or behavioral processes, such as intrinsic motivation, institutional commitment, and digital engagement orientation. These variables should collectively produce enhanced advocacy results for faculty.

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Dr. Fedric Kujur conceptualized the study, designed the research framework, and supervised the overall work. Dr. Rajib Roy contributed to data collection, analysis, interpretation of results, and manuscript writing. Both authors reviewed and approved the final version of the manuscript.

Author contributions

CRediT: **Fedric Kujur:** Conceptualization, Investigation, Methodology, Supervision; **Rajib Roy:** Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing.

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